

Negative Impacts of Social Media on Individual Autonomy

1. Disrespecting Autonomy
2. Interfering with the Exercise of Autonomy
3. Undermining Autonomy Competencies

1. Disrespecting Autonomy

Mechanisms # Data extraction and exploitation; # Surveillance capitalism
 # Deceptive or uninformed consent

Social media platforms collect and monetize vast amounts of user data, often without genuinely informed consent. Although users technically “agree” to terms of service. Privacy policies are either too complex to understand or too vague to be informative. Combined with social pressure to participate in social media, users often cannot reasonably refuse these terms.

How it harms to individual autonomy: This constitutes a disrespect for autonomy because users are treated as mere means for profit rather than as equal agents capable of determining fair terms of interaction. Exploitation takes advantage of users’ weaknesses, such as fear of missing out (FOMO) and the need for social connection, which means their consent is often neither fully voluntary nor properly informed. Surveillance makes people afraid of being watched, so they censor what they say or do online. Because of this, users feel less confident and less entitled to decide their own goals and values.

2. Interfering with the Exercise of Autonomy

Mechanisms: # Algorithmic control of attention #Content personalization and echo chambers
#Misinformation and fake news # Targeted and emotional advertising

Social media platforms decide what content users see and the order in which they see it. They use hidden algorithms that are designed to keep users engaged for as long as possible. These systems prioritize content that provokes strong emotional reactions, often leading to echo chambers, political polarization, and exposure to misinformation. In addition, targeted advertising exploits moments of emotional vulnerability to influence users' decisions.

How it harms to individual autonomy: These mechanisms interfere with both episodic autonomy (individual decisions) and programmatic or global autonomy (life-shaping values and identities). Users are pushed toward beliefs, purchases, and political positions they would not endorse if they were aware of how their attention was being manipulated. Because autonomy requires access to reliable information and genuine choice among alternatives, algorithmic distortion damages users' capacity for self-governance and reflective decision-making.

3. Weakens Autonomy Competencies

Mechanisms #Social comparison through likes, shares, and idealized content
 # Emotional manipulation # Addictive design features (infinite scroll, notifications, variable rewards)

Social media environments promote constant comparison with idealized standards of beauty, success, and happiness. Platforms also employ psychologically informed design features that foster habitual and addictive use, removing natural stopping cues and reinforcing obsessive engagement.

How it harms to individual autonomy: These practices weaken key autonomy competencies, such as self-esteem, self-respect, critical reflection, and emotional regulation. Lowered self-esteem makes individuals more susceptible to manipulation, while addiction compromises users' ability to control their time, attention, and long-term goals. Over time, this damages global autonomy, as users' identities, priorities, and life plans become increasingly transformed by platform-driven incentives rather than by their own reflective values